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Gout and diet: what to eat and avoid

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Gout is a type of arthritis caused by too much uric acid in the blood. When uric acid builds up, it can form tiny crystals inside a joint, often the big toe, and cause sudden, very painful swelling. Food is not the only cause of gout, but what you eat and drink can make attacks more or less likely.

Foods and drinks to limit

- **Organ meat**, such as liver, kidney and brain.
- **Red meat**, such as beef and mutton, especially large portions.
- **Shellfish**, such as prawns, shrimp and crab.
- **Sugary drinks**, such as soft drinks, packaged juices and energy drinks.
- **Alcohol**, especially beer.

You do not have to give up every one of these forever. Smaller portions, eaten less often, make a real difference.

Foods that are usually fine

- Vegetables, including green leafy vegetables.
- Rice, roti and other grains.
- Low-fat milk and yoghurt (doi).
- Eggs, and moderate portions of fish and chicken.

- Fruit, eaten whole rather than as juice.

Many people are told to avoid dal and some vegetables. Plant foods do not seem to raise the risk of attacks in the way that meat and sugary drinks do, so most people can keep eating them. Ask your doctor if you are not sure what is right for you.

Drink enough water

Water helps your kidneys remove uric acid. Drink enough through the day that your urine stays pale yellow, unless your doctor has asked you to limit fluids because of a heart or kidney problem.

Do not stop your uric-acid medicine on your own

Medicines that lower uric acid work slowly, over months. Some people stop taking them when the pain goes away, or during an attack. This often leads to more attacks later. If you have side effects or questions, talk to your doctor before you change anything.

A note for Ramadan and Eid

During Ramadan, long hours without water can raise uric acid. Drink plenty of water between iftar and sehri, and go easy on fried and very rich food.

At Eid, many families cook large amounts of beef and mutton, often with organ meat. Enjoy a small portion, fill the rest of your plate with rice, vegetables and salad, and keep drinking water. If you take

medicine for gout, ask your doctor before Ramadan how to time your doses.

When to get help

Contact a doctor quickly if you have a hot, swollen joint together with fever, because this can be an infection. Book a visit if attacks keep coming back, or if you notice lumps under the skin near your joints.

Diet alone rarely controls gout fully. Together with the right medicine and regular check-ups, most people can have far fewer attacks.

The information on this page is for general education only and does not replace a personal consultation. Please book an appointment for advice about your own condition.